

Ayoayo

Yoruba · south-western Nigeria

Players 2 · **Time** 15–30 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 2 × 6 pits, 2 stores, 48 seeds

Goal Capture more than half of the 48 seeds.

The Yoruba sowing game, played on the same board as oware. Before play you agree which number captures, 2 or 3; a last seed that makes that number in an enemy pit takes it, with any run of the same number behind it.

Setup 1. Put the board between the players. The 6 pits nearest you are yours, and the store on your right is yours. 2. Number your pits 1–6 from your own left. 3. Put 4 seeds in every pit. The stores start empty and are never sown into. 4. Agree the capturing number for the whole game: 2 or 3. 5. Decide by lot who begins †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 16 · large print p. 23

Bao la Kiswahili

Swahili · Zanzibar and the Tanzanian coast

Players 2 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 12 and up

Difficulty Expert (5 of 5)

You need 4 × 8 pits, 64 seeds

Goal Empty your opponent's inner row, or leave them without a legal move.

The four-row sowing game of Zanzibar. You sow round your own two rows. A sowing that ends opposite enemy seeds captures them, and they are sown straight back in on your side. Empty the enemy inner row, or leave them no move, to win.

Setup 1. Each player owns the 2 rows nearest them: the inner row, facing the opponent, and the outer row. 2. Number your pits 1–8 from your own left. Inner pit 5 is your nyumba (house); draw it square. 3. Your inner pits 1 and 8 are your kichwa (heads). Inner pits 2 and 7 are your kimbi. 4. Put 6 seeds in your nyumba and 2 in each of the next 2 inner pits to its right, 6 and 7. 5. Keep your other 22 seeds in hand. 6. Decide by lot who begins †. That player is South in the diagrams.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 18 · large print p. 28

Congkak

Malay · the Malay Peninsula

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 2 × 7 pits, 2 stores, 98 seeds

Goal Win all your opponent's seeds.

The Malay sowing game of the boat-shaped board. Sow right to left round the board, into your own store but never your opponent's. A last seed in a loaded pit carries on; in your store, play again; in an empty pit of yours, capture.

Setup 1. Put the board between the players. Your row of 7 pits is your village; the store at your left end is yours. 2. Number your pits 1–7 from your own left. 3. Put 7 seeds in every pit. The stores start empty.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 22 · large print p. 35

Gebeta

Amhara · Ethiopia

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 2 × 6 pits, 48 seeds

Goal Win all your opponent's pits over a series of rounds.

An Ethiopian sowing game. Sow and relay anticlockwise; a last seed that makes 4 in an enemy pit turns it into your ügg, which keeps every seed that later falls in. Rounds are scored in pits, and a player left with none has lost.

Setup 1. Put the board between the players. The 6 pits nearest you are yours; number them 1–6 from your own left. 2. Put 4 seeds in every pit. 3. Draw lots for who begins.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 24 · large print p. 40

Hus

Nama · Namaqualand, Namibia

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 4 × 12 pits, 72 seeds

Goal Capture all your opponent's seeds, or leave them unable to move.

A four-row sowing game from Namibia. Sow anticlockwise round your own two rows. End in a loaded inner pit opposite enemy seeds and you capture them and sow them on. A player left with only single seeds cannot move and loses.

Setup 1. Each player owns the 2 rows nearest them: the outer row and the inner row, facing the opponent. 2. Number the pits of each row 1–12 from your own left. 3. Put 2 seeds in every pit of your outer row. 4. Put 2 seeds in each pit of the right half of your inner row, pits 7–12. Leave pits 1–6 empty. 5. Decide by agreement or by chance who begins. In later games the winner of the last game begins.
Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 28 · large print p. 45

Mefuvha

Venda · Venda country, northern Transvaal (Limpopo, South Africa)

Players 2 · **Time** 15–30 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 4 × 6 pits, 42 stones

Goal Capture all your opponent's stones.

The Venda cattle-raid game. Each player sows round their own two rows. A sowing that stops in an empty inner pit opposite enemy stones is a hit: take them, the pit behind, and one more pit of your choice. Take every enemy stone to win.

Setup 1. Each player owns the 2 rows nearest them: the inner row, facing the opponent, and the outer row. 2. Number the pits of each row 1–6 from your own left. 3. Put 2 stones in every pit of your 2 rows, except inner pits 1 and 2. 4. Leave inner pit 1 empty and put 1 stone in inner pit 2. That makes 21 stones each. 5. Decide who begins †.
Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 30 · large print p. 51

Olinda Keliya

Sinhalese · the Kandyan hill country of Sri Lanka

Players 2 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 2 × 7 pits, 2 stores, 56 seeds

Goal Capture all your opponent's seeds over a series of rounds.

The favourite olinda game of the Kandyan Sinhalese. Sow round the board and relay from the pit where your last seed falls. Pits of 3 are skipped, but a last seed that makes 4 eats them. Rounds go on until one player has every seed.

Setup 1. Put the board between the players. The 7 pits nearest you are yours; number them 1–7 from your own left. 2. Put 4 seeds in every pit. The stores start empty. 3. Decide who begins †. The first player chooses the direction of play, left or right; both keep it for the round.
Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 34 · large print p. 57

Omweeso

Ganda · Buganda, Uganda

Players 2 · **Time** 10–30 minutes · **Age** 10 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 4 × 8 pits, 64 seeds

Goal Capture your opponent's seeds until they cannot move.

The four-row sowing game of Buganda. Sow round your own two rows. End in your inner row opposite two loaded enemy pits and you take both, sowing the seeds back in as your own. A player without a pit of 2 seeds loses.

Setup 1. Each player owns the 2 rows nearest them: the outer row and the inner row, facing the opponent. 2. Number the pits of each row 1–8 from your own left. 3. Put 4 seeds in every pit of your outer row. This checks that you have 32. 4. Each player may now rearrange their own 32 seeds among their 16 pits as they please. 5. Either player may begin. In later games the loser of the last game begins.
Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 38 · large print p. 63

Oware

Akan · Asante, Ghana

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 2 × 6 pits, 2 stores, 48 seeds

Goal Capture more than half of the 48 seeds.

The best-known sowing game of West Africa. Sow round the board one lap at a time; a last seed that makes 2 or 3 in an enemy pit captures it and the 2s and 3s behind it. Capture 25 seeds to win.

Setup 1. Put the board between the players. The 6 pits nearest you are yours, and the store on your right is yours. 2. Number your pits 1–6 from your own left. 3. Put 4 seeds in every pit. The stores start empty and are never sown into. 4. Decide by lot who begins †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 42 · large print p. 70

Pallanguzhi

Tamil · Tamil Nadu and Sri Lanka

Players 2 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 2 × 7 pits, 2 stores, 84 seeds

Goal Leave your opponent too few seeds to fill a single pit.

The Tamil sowing game of the fourteen-pit board. After each lap, lift the pit after your last seed and carry on; an empty pit gives you the pit beyond it. Four seeds make a cow for the pit's owner. Rounds end in ruin.

Setup 1. Put the board between the players. The 7 pits nearest you and your store are yours. 2. Number your pits 1–7 from your own left. 3. Put 6 seeds in every pit. The stores start empty. 4. Decide who opens the first round †. The first move alternates from round to round.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 44 · large print p. 76

Catch the Hare

Castilian · Castile

Players 2 · **Time** 10–20 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 5 × 5-point lined board, 1 hare, 12 hunters

Goal The hunters try to trap the hare so that it cannot move; the hare tries to capture hunters until only 9 are left.

A hunt game on the lined alquerque board: 1 hare against 12 hunters. Each turn, move one piece one step along a line. Only the hare captures, by jumping. The hunters win by trapping the hare; the hare wins by reducing them to 9.

Setup 1. Draw the board (see the diagram). 2. Seat the hunters' player at the row 1 edge. Letters a–e run left to right; rows count away from that player. 3. Choose who plays the hare. 4. Put the hare on the centre point, c3. 5. Put 10 hunters on all 10 points of rows 1 and 2. 6. Put the last 2 hunters on the ends of row 3: a3 and e3.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 48 · large print p. 85

Diviyan Keliya

Sinhalese · Sri Lanka (Ceylon)

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 49-point lined board, 2 leopards, 24 cattle

Goal The cattle try to shut both leopards in so that neither can move; the leopards try to capture 8 cattle.

A two-player hunt game on a 49-point board. The leopard player places 2 leopards; the cattle player feeds in 24 cattle one by one. Leopards capture by jumping. The cattle win by leaving both leopards unable to move; the leopards win by capturing 8.

Setup 1. Draw the 49-point board (see the diagram). 2. Choose who plays the 2 leopards. The other player takes the 24 cattle. 3. Start with the board empty: every piece begins in hand. 4. The leopard player takes the first turn.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 52 · large print p. 91

Fox and Geese

English · England

Players 2 · **Time** 10–20 minutes · **Age** 6 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 33-point cross board, 1 fox, 17 geese

Goal The geese try to hem the fox in so that it cannot move; the fox tries to capture geese until only 9 are left.

A hunt game on a cross-shaped board: 1 fox against 17 geese. Each turn, move one piece a step along a line. Only the fox captures, by jumping. The geese win by trapping the fox; the fox wins by reducing them to 9.

Setup 1. Draw the board (see the diagram). Points are named a–g left to right and 1–7 upwards. 2. Seat the geese player at the end of the bottom arm. 3. Put the fox on the centre point, d4. 4. Fill the bottom arm with 6 geese: c1, d1, e1, c2, d2 and e2. 5. Fill the whole row above it with 7 geese, from a3 to g3. 6. Put the last 4 geese on the 2 outer points at each end of the fox's row: a4, b4, f4 and g4. 7. Check: c4 and e4, beside the fox, are empty, and so is everything above row 4.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 56 · large print p. 98

Hnefatafl

Norse · Scandinavia and the lands of Norse settlement, including Iceland, Britain and Ireland

Players 2 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 10 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 11 × 11 board, 1 king, 12 defenders, 24 besiegers

Goal The king's side tries to bring the king to a corner square; the besiegers try to capture the king.

A siege game on an 11 × 11 board: a king and 12 defenders in the centre, 24 besiegers at the edges.

Pieces move like chess rooks and capture by sandwiching. The king wins by reaching a corner; the besiegers win by surrounding him.

Setup 1. Rule the board. Mark the centre square, f6, as the throne, and mark the 4 corner squares. 2. Stand the king on the throne. 3. Put a defender on each of the 8 squares touching the king, diagonals included. 4. Put 1 more defender 2 squares from the king in each straight direction: f4, f8, d6 and h6. 5. In the middle of each edge put 5 besiegers in a row: d1–h1, d11–h11, a4–a8 and k4–k8. 6. Put 1 more besieger just inside the middle of each row: f2, f10, b6 and j6.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 60 · large print p. 105

Rimau-rimau

Malay · the Malay Peninsula

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 37-point lined board, 1 tiger, 24 men

Goal The men try to hem the tiger in so that it cannot move; the tiger tries to capture men until only 10 are left.

1 tiger against 24 men on a 37-point board. The tiger opens by removing 3 men; the rest are fed in one at a time. The tiger captures by leaping 1, 3 or 5 men in a row. The men win by trapping it.

Setup 1. Draw the board with a gunung at top and bottom (see the diagram). 2. Choose who plays the tiger. The other player takes the 24 men. 3. Put 9 men on the centre and the 8 points around it: b4–d4, b5–d5 and b6–d6. 4. Keep the other 15 men in hand. 5. Put the tiger on the tip of either gunung, where it meets the square: c7 or c3.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 64 · large print p. 114

Tablut

Sámi · Sápmi (Lapland), northern Sweden

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 9 × 9 board, 1 king, 8 defenders, 16 besiegers

Goal The king's side tries to bring the king to any edge square; the besiegers try to capture the king.

A siege game on a 9 × 9 board: a king and 8 defenders in the centre, 16 besiegers at the edges. Pieces move like chess rooks and capture by sandwiching. The king wins by reaching any edge square; the besiegers win by capturing him.

Setup 1. Rule the board and mark the centre square, e5. This is the castle, which Linnaeus calls konokis. 2. Stand the king on the castle. 3. Put a defender on each of the 4 squares touching the king: e4, e6, d5 and f5. 4. Put 1 more defender 2 squares from the king in each of those directions: e3, e7, c5 and g5. 5. In the middle of each edge put 3 besiegers side by side: d1–f1, d9–f9, a4–a6 and i4–i6. 6. Put 1 more besieger just inside the middle of each group: e2, e8, b5 and h5.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 68 · large print p. 121

Ashta Kashte

Bengali · Bengal

Players 2–4 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 7 × 7 board, 4 pieces each, 4 cowrie shells

Goal Be the first to bring all four pieces along the spiral to the centre.

A Bengali race on a 7 × 7 board. Throw four cowries; enter at the castle in front of you, run the outer ring anticlockwise, then spiral inwards the other way to the centre. Castles are safe, and a capture earns another throw.

Setup 1. Each player sits at a side of the board. The castle in the middle of your side is your entry castle. 2. Keep your 4 pieces off the board. With two players, sit opposite each other. 3. Each player throws; the highest throw begins †, and the turn passes to the right.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 76 · large print p. 135

E-Sugoroku

Japanese · Japan

Players 2–6 · **Time** 20–30 minutes · **Age** 5 and up

Difficulty Very easy (1 of 5)

You need the board in this book, 1 piece each, 1 die

Goal Be the first traveller to reach Kyoto.

The Japanese New Year picture game. Travellers race along a printed journey by the throw of a die, stopping at picture squares that send them on, back or to rest. This book's board is the old high road from Edo to Kyoto.

Setup 1. Every traveller starts at Nihonbashi in Edo, the start square. 2. Each player throws the die; the highest throw begins †, and play passes to the left.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 78 · large print p. 142

Li'b el-Merajib

Baggara · Kordofan and Darfur, Sudan

Players 2 or more · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need a spiral track, 1 marker each, 3 split sticks

Goal Bring your mother home from the well first, and loose the hyena on the others.

A Sudanese race along a spiral scratched in the sand. Each player's 'mother' walks to the well at the centre and back, paying special throws, tabas, to leave, drink and wash. The first home looses a hyena that eats the mothers still on the road.

Setup 1. All the mothers start in the village, the outer end of the spiral. 2. Keep a pile of small stones or a pencil and paper to count each player's tabas. 3. Decide who begins †; the sticks then pass to the left.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 82 · large print p. 148

Ludus Duodecim Scriptorum

Roman · the Roman world

Players 2 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 10 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 3 × 12 board, 15 pieces each, 3 dice

Goal Be the first to bring all fifteen pieces round the board and off it.

A Roman race game of the backgammon kind on three rows of twelve points. Enter all your pieces, run them round the board with three dice, hit lone enemy pieces, and bear off from the last six points.

Setup 1. Put the board between the players. Both players' pieces follow the same route, in the same direction. 2. The route: along the middle row (A) from left to right; up and back along the top row (B, then C). 3. Then down and along the bottom row (D, then E), and off the board at the right. 4. Number the points 1–36 along the route. All pieces start off the board. 5. Each player throws one die; the higher throw begins †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 86 · large print p. 155

Pachisi

Deccani · India; the account given here was written in the Deccan

Players 4 (or 2) · **Time** 45–90 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need cross-shaped board, 4 pieces each, 6 cowrie shells

Goal Be the first to take all four pieces round the cross and back to the centre.

The cross-shaped race game of India. Throw six cowries and move your pieces out from the centre, anticlockwise round the whole cross and home again. Land on an enemy piece to send it back, except on the twelve forts.

Setup 1. Each player sits at one arm of the cross; that arm is theirs. All pieces start in the central square. 2. Each player throws once; the highest throw begins, and play passes to the right †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 90 · large print p. 161

Patolli

Nahua · central Mexico

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need cross-shaped board, 6 pieces each, 5 marked beans

Goal Be the first to take all six of your pieces round the cross and into the centre.

The Aztec race game on a mat painted with a great cross. Throw five marked beans and move your stones round all four arms and into the middle. The rules below are a reconstruction: the chroniclers describe the game but not its moves.

Setup 1. Draw the cross (see the diagram). Players sit at opposite arms, South and North. 2. Each player keeps 6 stones of one colour off the board. The highest throw begins †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 94 · large print p. 168

Puluc

Q'eqchi' Maya · Alta Verapaz, Guatemala

Players 2 · **Time** 15–30 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 10 maize kernels, 5 sticks each, 4 flat kernels as dice

Goal Kill all five of your opponent's warriors.

A Maya race-and-fight game on a road of ten maize kernels. Your sticks run to the far end and round again; land on an enemy stick and you drag it home as a prisoner, where it dies. Lose all five and you have lost.

Setup 1. Sit facing each other with the road of 10 kernels between you. Your end of the road is your home. 2. Number the kernels 1–10 from your own end. Each player keeps 5 sticks off the road. 3. Each player throws; the higher throws again and begins. Then take turns.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 98 · large print p. 175

Senet

Ancient Egyptian · Egypt

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 3 × 10 board, 5 pieces each, 4 throwing sticks

Goal Be the first to take all your pieces off the far end of the board.

Egypt's ancient race game on thirty squares. Pieces run an S-shaped route, pass and bump each other, and must cross special squares near the end. The last three squares need an exact throw to leave.

Setup 1. Number the squares 1–30: row 1 from left to right, row 2 from right to left, row 3 from left to right. 2. Put the 10 pieces on squares 1–10, alternating: White on 1, Black on 2, White on 3, and so on. 3. Black's piece on 10 is at the front. White begins †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 100 · large print p. 180

Set-dilth

White Mountain Apache · White River, Arizona

Players 2–4 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 40 stones in a circle, 1 marker each, 3 split sticks

Goal Be the first to take your marker three times round the circle of stones.

The White Mountain Apache stick game. Three split sticks thrown against a stone move your marker round a circle of forty stones. Land on or pass an opponent's marker and you send it back to the start. Three circuits win.

Setup 1. Mark the gap at the north-east as the start. All markers begin there. 2. With four players, partners sit opposite. One partnership moves clockwise, the other anticlockwise. 3. With two players, one moves each way †. Decide who begins †; the sticks then pass round in turn.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 104 · large print p. 186

Tab

Modern Egyptian · Egypt

Players 2 · **Time** 20–45 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 4 × 9 board, 9 pieces each, 4 throwing sticks

Goal Take every one of your opponent's pieces.

An Egyptian race-and-capture game for two, played with four flat sticks. Each piece must be woken by a throw of tab before it can run the middle rows; land on an enemy piece to take it. Take them all to win.

Setup 1. Seat the players at the long sides. Your home row is the row nearest you; the two middle rows are shared. 2. Put one of your pieces on every square of your home row. 3. Both players throw the sticks in turn until one throws tab. That player begins.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 106 · large print p. 193

The Royal Game of Ur

Mesopotamian · Mesopotamia and the ancient Near East

Players 2 · **Time** 20–30 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 20-square board, 7 pieces each, 4 four-sided dice

Goal Be the first to take all seven of your pieces round the board and off it.

A race for two on the twenty-square board from the royal tombs of Ur. Throw the dice and move; a rosette gives another throw, and landing on an enemy piece in the middle row sends it back. Bring all seven home to win.

Setup 1. Put the board between the players, the long side towards each. Your row is the one nearest you. 2. Each player keeps 7 pieces off the board, beside their own row. 3. Each player throws the dice; the higher throw begins †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 108 · large print p. 199

Totolospi

Hopi · Oraibi and Walpi, Arizona

Players 2 · **Time** 5–15 minutes · **Age** 5 and up

Difficulty Very easy (1 of 5)

You need an oval board with 10 lines, 1 piece each, 3 cane dice

Goal Be the first to cross the board to the circle at your opponent's end.

A Hopi race across an oval cut in stone. Throw three cane dice: three white move you 2 lines, three red 1 line, anything else passes the dice. First across wins.

Setup 1. Put the board between you, lengthways. Each player's piece starts on the circle nearest them. 2. Throw once each; the higher begins †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 112 · large print p. 205

Yut Nori

Korean · Korea

Players 2–4 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 6 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 29-station board, 1–4 horses each, 4 throwing sticks

Goal Be the first to take all your horses round the board and out.

Korea's New Year race game. Throw four sticks and move your horses round a circle of twenty stations; land on a corner and you may cut across the middle. Land on an enemy to send it back; land on your own horse to carry both.

Setup 1. Agree how many horses each side must bring home, from 1 to 4. 2. With 4 players, partners sit opposite and may move each other's horses. 3. Each player throws; the highest throw goes first, and the others follow in order of their throws.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 114 · large print p. 209

Zohn Ahl

Kiowa · Oklahoma

Players 2 sides · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need a circle of 40 marks, 2 awls, 4 stick dice, 8 counters

Goal Win all the counters for your side.

A Kiowa stick-dice race round a circle of forty marks. Two sides race opposite ways from the south creek; stop in the north creek and you fall in, catch the enemy marker and you whip it. Each circuit wins a counter.

Setup 1. Players divide into two sides, half on each side of the line from the south creek to the north creek. 2. Put both markers in the south creek. Put the 8 counters in a pile between the sides. 3. Players throw in turn, clockwise round the circle †, starting with any player.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 116 · large print p. 216

Achi

Gold Coast · Gold Coast (now Ghana); recorded at Nopa, Nigeria

Players 2 · **Time** 10–20 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 16-point board, 6 pieces each

Goal Take your opponent's pieces until they have only two left.

A West African morris game on two nested squares. Each player enters six pieces, then moves them along the lines. A row of three, or a pair on one of the short cross-lines, takes an enemy piece. Leave your opponent two pieces and you win.

Setup 1. Draw the board: two squares, one inside the other, joined at the middles of their sides by four short cross-lines. 2. Check the 16 points: 8 on each square, at the corners and the middles of the sides. 3. Each player takes 6 pieces. The board starts empty. 4. Decide by lot who starts †; after that, take turns.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 120 · large print p. 226

Dara

Dakarkari · Sokoto Province, north-western Nigeria

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 5 × 6 holes or squares, 12 pieces each

Goal Make rows of exactly three and take your opponent's pieces until they have only two left.

A three-in-a-row game from northern Nigeria, played in thirty holes in the ground. Each player places twelve pieces, then moves them one step at a time. Every row of exactly three takes an enemy piece. Reduce your opponent to two pieces to win.

Setup 1. Make the board: 30 holes, 6 across and 5 deep, or a grid of 6 × 5 squares. 2. Each player takes 12 pieces. The board starts empty. 3. Decide by lot who places first †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 124 · large print p. 233

Go

Chinese · China, Korea and Japan

Players 2 · **Time** 20–90 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 19 × 19 or 9 × 9 board, black and white stones

Goal Surround more of the board than your opponent.

The great surrounding game of East Asia. Players take turns placing stones on the points of a lined board; stones that are completely surrounded are captured. When both pass, the player who controls more of the board wins.

Setup 1. Use a board of 19 × 19 lines. The usual smaller boards are 9 × 9 and 13 × 13. 2. The board starts empty. One player takes the black stones, the other the white. 3. Black plays first. White receives 7½ points at the end for moving second.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 126 · large print p. 239

Gomoku

Japanese · Japan

Players 2 · **Time** 5–20 minutes · **Age** 6 and up

Difficulty Very easy (1 of 5)

You need 15 × 15 or go board, stones of two colours

Goal Be the first to get five of your stones in an unbroken line.

The Japanese five-in-a-row game, played with go stones on the points of a lined board. Players take turns placing one stone each; stones never move and are never captured. The first to make an unbroken line of five, in any direction, wins.

Setup 1. Use a board of 15 × 15 lines, or a go board of 19 × 19. 2. The board starts empty. One player takes black stones, the other white. 3. Black plays first, on the centre point.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 130 · large print p. 246

Mū Tōrere

Māori · East Cape district (Ngāti Porou), Aotearoa New Zealand

Players 2 · **Time** 5–15 minutes · **Age** 6 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need eight-pointed star, 4 pieces each

Goal Leave your opponent with no legal move.

A Māori blocking game on an eight-pointed star. Each player has four pieces, and exactly one place is ever empty. Move a piece into it along a line; whoever cannot move on their turn loses.

Setup 1. Draw the board: 8 points in a ring, each joined to its two neighbours and to the centre. 2. Number the points 1–8 round the ring. White takes points 1–4, Black points 5–8. 3. The centre starts empty. Black moves first.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 132 · large print p. 251

Nerenchi

Sinhalese · Sri Lanka

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 24-point board, 12 pieces each

Goal Take all your opponent's pieces by making rows of three.

The Sinhalese form of the great morris game. Players fill the board until two points are empty, earning an extra piece for every row of three. Then they move; each new row takes an enemy piece and earns another move.

Setup 1. Draw the board: three squares, one inside another, joined at the middles of their sides by four lines. 2. Check the 24 points: the corners and side-middles of each square. 3. Each player takes 12 pieces. The board starts empty. 4. Decide by lot who places first †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 134 · large print p. 257

Nine Men's Morris

English · England

Players 2 · **Time** 15–30 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 24-point board, 9 pieces each

Goal Take your opponent's pieces until they have only two left, or leave them unable to move.

The English morris game on three nested squares. Players enter nine pieces each, then move them along the lines. Every mill, a row of three, takes an enemy piece. Reduce your opponent to two pieces, or block them, to win.

Setup 1. Draw the board: three squares, one inside another, joined at the middles of their sides. 2. Each player takes 9 pieces. The board starts empty. 3. Decide by lot who starts †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 138 · large print p. 264

Picaria

Tewa · Santa Clara Pueblo, New Mexico; the name *picaria* is from *Isleta Pueblo* (Tiwa)

Players 2 · **Time** 5–10 minutes · **Age** 6 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 9-point board, 3 pieces each

Goal Make rows of three and send all your opponent's pieces to the centre pile.

A Pueblo three-in-a-row game on nine points. Each player places three pieces, then moves them along the lines. Every row of three sends one enemy piece to a pile in the middle; the first to lose all three pieces loses.

Setup 1. Draw the board: a square, its two diagonals, and the two lines joining the middles of opposite sides. 2. Each player takes 3 pieces †. The board starts empty. 3. Decide by lot who places first †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 140 · large print p. 271

Pong Hau K'i

Chinese · Guangdong (Cantonese *pong hau k'i*); the same game is played in Korea

Players 2 · **Time** 2–10 minutes · **Age** 5 and up

Difficulty Very easy (1 of 5)

You need 5-point board, 2 pieces each

Goal Leave your opponent with no legal move.

A Cantonese blocking game on five points: a square with its diagonals and one side missing. Each player has two pieces and one point is always empty. Slide a piece into it; whoever cannot move on their turn loses.

Setup 1. Draw the board: a square with both diagonals, leaving out one side. 2. Black puts 2 pieces on the two corners at the ends of the missing side. 3. White puts 2 pieces on the other two corners. The centre starts empty. 4. Black moves first.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 144 · large print p. 277

Alquerque

Castilian · Castile, Spain; the name reached Spanish through Arabic

Players 2 · **Time** 15–30 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 5 × 5 board of points with slanting lines, 12 pieces each, a die or coin

Goal Capture more of your opponent's pieces than they capture of yours — all of them, if you can.

A leaping war game on 25 points. On your turn you step one piece along a line, or leap over an enemy piece to capture it, often several in one turn. Capturing is compulsory. The player left with more pieces wins.

Setup 1. Set the board between the two players. 2. Give each player 12 pieces, Black or White. 3. Black fills the 10 points of the 2 rows nearest them. 4. Black also fills the 2 middle-row points on their own right, a3 and b3. 5. White fills the 10 points of the 2 rows nearest them. 6. White also fills the 2 middle-row points on their own right, d3 and e3. 7. Leave the centre point, c3, empty. It is the only empty point. 8. Throw a die or toss a coin to decide who moves first.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 148 · large print p. 286

Awithlalnannai

Zuni · Zuni Pueblo, New Mexico

Players 2 · **Time** 15–30 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 47-point serpent board, 23 pieces each

Goal Capture all your opponent's pieces by jumping them. A Zuni jumping game on a long, narrow board called the serpent. Pieces step along the lines and capture by jumping an enemy piece. The first move into the empty centre is jumped at once, and the fight spreads from there.

Setup 1. Lay the board lengthways between you, one long side towards each player. 2. Black fills the far line and the 7 middle points on Black's right. 3. White fills the near line and the 7 middle points on White's right. 4. Only the centre point, the 8th of the middle line, stays empty. 5. Decide by lot who starts †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 152 · large print p. 293

Chaturaji

Bengali · Bengal

Players 4 (two partnerships) · **Time** 45–90 minutes · **Age** 10 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 8 × 8 board, 4 armies of 8, 1 die

Goal With your partner opposite you, capture both enemy kings, or every enemy piece except the kings.

Chess for four, in two partnerships, ruled by a die.

Each turn you throw and must move the kind of piece the throw names. Kings can be captured, and there is no check. The partners who take both enemy kings win.

Setup 1. Seat the four players round the board, one at each edge. 2. Partners sit opposite: Green (bottom) with Black (top), and Red (right) with Yellow (left). 3. Each army starts in its owner's left-hand corner: boat in the corner, then horse, elephant and king along the edge. 4. Put 4 pawns on the squares directly in front of those 4 pieces. 5. In the diagram: Green a1–d1 with pawns a2–d2; Red h1–h4 with pawns g1–g4. 6. Black h8–e8 with pawns h7–e7; Yellow a8–a5 with pawns b8–b5. 7. Each player throws the die; the highest throw starts †. The turn then passes to the left †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 154 · large print p. 298

Fanorona

Malagasy · Imerina, central Madagascar

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 5 × 9 board of points, 22 pieces each

Goal Capture every one of your opponent's pieces.

A capturing game on 45 points. You take a whole line of enemy pieces by moving towards it (approach) or away from it (withdrawal). Capturing is compulsory, and one piece may capture again and again in a turn. Take every enemy piece to win.

Setup 1. Set the board between you, long sides towards the players. 2. White fills every point of the 2 rows nearest them: 18 pieces. 3. Black fills every point of the 2 rows nearest them. 4. On the middle row, put Black on a3, c3, f3 and h3, and White on b3, d3, g3 and i3. 5. Leave the centre point, e3, empty. Montgomery calls it the foibeny, 'the navel'. 6. White moves first †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 158 · large print p. 307

Hasami Shogi

Japanese · Japan

Players 2 · **Time** 10–20 minutes · **Age** 6 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 9 × 9 board, 9 pieces each

Goal Be the first to capture 5 enemy pieces, or to lead by 3. Japan's sandwich game, played with shogi pawns on the shogi board. Pieces move like rooks; trap an enemy piece between two of yours to take it. The first to take five pieces, or to lead by three, wins.

Setup 1. Place the board between you. 2. Each player puts 9 pieces on the row of squares nearest them, one in each square. 3. Decide by lot who moves first †; that player is Black.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 162 · large print p. 315

Janggi

Korean · Korea

Players 2 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 9 × 10 lined board, 2 sets of 16 pieces

Goal Checkmate the enemy general.

Korean chess on the points of a 9 × 10 board with no river. Generals start in the middle of their palaces, cannons must jump to move at all, and the generals may stand face to face. Checkmate wins.

Setup 1. Blue (cho) sits at row 1 and Red (han) at row 10. Points are named by file a–i and row 1–10. 2. Toss for colours: Blue moves first. Red sets up first, then Blue. 3. Put chariots on a1 and i1, advisers on d1 and f1, and the general on e2, the palace centre. 4. Put a horse and an elephant on b1 and c1, in either order; the same on g1 and h1. 5. Put the cannons on b3 and h3, and soldiers on a4, c4, e4, g4 and i4. 6. Red sets up the same way from row 10: general on e9, cannons on b8 and h8, soldiers on row 7.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 164 · large print p. 321

Jeu de Dames

French · France, and from there the Low Countries and beyond

Players 2 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 10 × 10 board, 20 pieces each

Goal Capture all your opponent's pieces, or leave them unable to move.

Draughts on a board of a hundred squares. Men move diagonally forward but capture forwards and backwards; kings fly along the diagonals. Capturing is compulsory, and you must take the most pieces you can.

Setup 1. Place the board so that each player has a dark square in the corner on their left. 2. Play only on the dark squares. 3. White puts 20 men on the dark squares of the 4 rows nearest them; Black does the same on the other side. 4. The 2 middle rows start empty. White moves first.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 168 · large print p. 329

Polis

Ancient Greek · Greece

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 8 × 8 board, 16 pieces each

Goal Capture more of your opponent's pieces than they capture of yours.

The Greek game of 'cities' and 'dogs'. Players place sixteen pieces each on a squared board, then move them one square at a time. Trap an enemy piece between two of yours to take it. The player with more pieces at the end wins.

Setup 1. Use a board of 8 × 8 squares †. It starts empty. 2. Each player takes 16 pieces of one colour †. 3. Decide by lot who starts †. 4. Take turns placing 2 pieces at a time on any empty squares, until all 32 are down †. 5. Nothing is captured while placing †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 172 · large print p. 336

Seega

Modern Egyptian · Egypt, among the fellaheen

Players 2 · **Time** 15–30 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 5 × 5 holes or squares, 12 pieces each

Goal Capture your opponent's pieces by trapping them between two of yours.

An Egyptian trapping game. Players place twelve pieces each, two at a time, leaving only the centre empty, then move one step at a time. Trap an enemy piece between two of yours to take it.

Setup 1. The board starts empty. Decide by lot who places first †; call that player White. 2. White places 2 pieces in the middles of the top and bottom rows, c5 and c1. 3. Black places 2 pieces in the middles of the side columns, a3 and e3. 4. Then take turns placing 2 pieces at a time in any empty holes except the centre. 5. Stop when all 24 are down. Only the centre, c3, is empty.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 176 · large print p. 342

Shatranj

Abbasid · Persia and the lands of the caliphate

Players 2 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 8 × 8 board, 2 sets of 16 pieces

Goal Checkmate the enemy king, leave it without a move, or capture every piece it has.

The chess of the medieval Islamic world, on the modern board with slower pieces: the counsellor steps one square diagonally and the elephant leaps two. Win by checkmate, by stalemate, or by capturing everything but the king.

Setup 1. Put the board between the players. Red sits at the row 1 edge. 2. Red: rooks on a1 and h1, horses on b1 and g1, elephants on c1 and f1. 3. Red's king goes on d1 and counsellor on e1. 4. Black sets up the same way on row 8, with the king on d8 and counsellor on e8. 5. The two kings face each other along the d-file, and the two counsellors along the e-file. 6. Put 8 pawns on each player's second row: row 2 for Red, row 7 for Black. 7. Red moves first †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 180 · large print p. 348

Shogi

Japanese · Japan

Players 2 · **Time** 30–90 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Expert (5 of 5)

You need 9 × 9 board, 2 sets of 20 pieces

Goal Checkmate the enemy king.

Japanese chess on a 9 × 9 board. Most pieces are promoted in the enemy camp, and a captured piece joins your side: you may drop it back on the board instead of moving. Checkmate wins.

Setup 1. Black sits at row 1 and White at row 9. Squares are named by file a–i and row 1–9. 2. Black's row 1, a to i: lance, knight, silver, gold, king, gold, silver, knight, lance. 3. Black's bishop goes on b2 and rook on h2; the 9 pawns fill row 3. 4. White sets up the same way from row 9: rook on b8, bishop on h8, pawns on row 7. 5. To choose who is Black, toss 5 pawns: if more land unpromoted side up, the tosser plays Black. 6. Black moves first.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 184 · large print p. 355

Sittuyin

Burmese · Burma (Myanmar)

Players 2 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 10 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 8 × 8 board with 2 diagonals, 2 sets of 16 pieces

Goal Checkmate the enemy king.

Burmese chess: the pawns start in fixed staggered lines, and each player sets out the other pieces behind them before the fighting starts. The general steps diagonally, and a pawn may become a general only on a diagonal. Checkmate wins.

Setup 1. Red sits at row 1 and Black at row 8. 2. Red's pawns go on a3, b3, c3 and d3, and on e4, f4, g4 and h4. 3. Black's pawns go on e6, f6, g6 and h6, and on a5, b5, c5 and d5. The pawns never start elsewhere. 4. Now the players take turns placing the other pieces, 1 at a time, Red first †. 5. Place each piece on any empty square of your own half, behind or among your pawns. 6. Or use the Rangoon formation in the diagram: king g2, general f3, elephants f2 and g3. 7. It continues: horses d2 and e2, chariots a1 and h1. Black's is the same, turned round.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 188 · large print p. 363

Turkish Dama

Turkish · Turkey and the eastern Mediterranean

Players 2 · **Time** 20–40 minutes · **Age** 8 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need 8 × 8 board, 16 pieces each

Goal Capture all your opponent's pieces, or leave them unable to move.

Draughts played on straight lines instead of diagonals. Men step forward or sideways and capture by jumping; a man reaching the far row becomes a dama, which moves like a chess rook. Capturing is compulsory, and you must take the most pieces you can.

Setup 1. White puts 16 men on the second and third rows from their side, filling both rows. 2. Black does the same on the sixth and seventh rows. 3. The first, fourth, fifth and eighth rows stay empty. 4. White moves first †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 192 · large print p. 370

Xiangqi

Chinese · China

Players 2 · **Time** 20–45 minutes · **Age** 9 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 9 × 10 lined board, 2 sets of 16 discs

Goal Checkmate the enemy general, or leave your opponent with no legal move.

Chess on the points of a board cut by a river. Each general is confined to a small palace, elephants may not cross the river, and the cannon captures by leaping. Checkmate or stalemate the enemy general to win.

Setup 1. Red sits at row 1 and Black at row 10. Points are named by file a–i and row 1–10. 2. Red's back row, a1 to i1: chariot, horse, elephant, adviser, general, adviser, elephant, horse, chariot. 3. Red's cannons go on b3 and h3; the 5 soldiers on a4, c4, e4, g4 and i4. 4. Black mirrors this: back row on row 10, cannons on b8 and h8, soldiers on a7, c7, e7, g7 and i7. 5. Red moves first.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 196 · large print p. 377

Astragaloi

Ancient Greek · Greece and the Greek-speaking Mediterranean

Players 2–4 · **Time** 10–20 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 4 knucklebones (or 4 dice), pencil and paper

Goal Throw the highest total with four knucklebones, round after round, and be the first to 30 points.

A Greek throwing game. Each round, every player throws four knucklebones and adds the faces, worth 1, 3, 4 or 6. The highest total wins the round and scores its margin over each rival. First to 30 points wins.

Setup 1. Sit round a table or a patch of smooth floor. 2. Put 4 bones in the middle (or 4 dice read as bones; see Materials). 3. Learn the faces from the chart: broad bulging side 4, broad hollow side 3, narrow flat side 1, narrow grooved side 6. 4. Draw a score sheet with one column for each player. 5. Choose anyone to throw first; the order does not affect the result †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 202 · large print p. 386

Tien Gow

Chinese · Guangdong; recorded among Cantonese workers in the United States

Players 4 · **Time** 30–60 minutes · **Age** 10 and up

Difficulty Demanding (4 of 5)

You need 32 Chinese dominoes, paper for scores

Goal Take the last round of each game, and avoid finishing a game with few tricks.

A Chinese trick-taking game with the 32 Chinese dominoes. Four players hold eight pieces each and lead singles, pairs or sets; a play wins only if it is higher and of the same kind. Whoever takes the last round wins the game.

Setup 1. Four players sit round a table. 2. Mix the 32 pieces face down and build them into 8 piles of 4. 3. Throw 2 dice and count round the table to choose the first player for this game. 4. The first player takes 2 piles; then each player in turn to the right takes 2 piles †. 5. Everyone now holds 8 pieces. Keep them hidden.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 206 · large print p. 392

Cat's Cradle

English · England and North America; played across Europe and East Asia

Players 2 · **Time** 5–15 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Moderate (3 of 5)

You need a loop of string

Goal Pass the string back and forth through all eight figures without a tangle.

A string game for two. One player makes the Cradle on their hands; the other takes it off to make the next figure, and so on through eight named figures, ending with the Clock.

Setup 1. Tie the string into a loop. Player A starts; B sits facing A. 2. 'Near', 'far', 'left' and 'right' are always as seen by the player holding the figure. 3. A 'palm string' is a string running across the palm of a hand.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 212 · large print p. 402

Conkers

English · England

Players 2 · **Time** 2–10 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Very easy (1 of 5)

You need horse chestnuts on strings

Goal Break your opponent's conker with yours.

The autumn game of horse chestnuts on strings. Players take turns to strike, three blows at a time, at the other's hanging conker. The first conker to be smashed loses, and the winner takes over its score.

Setup 1. Toss a coin. The winner chooses to strike or to receive first. 2. The receiver wraps the string round one hand and lets the conker hang still, at the height the striker chooses.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 216 · large print p. 410

Gonggi

Korean · Korea

Players 1 or more · **Time** 10–20 minutes · **Age** 6 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need 5 small stones

Goal Pass all five levels and score points with the back-of-hand catch, first to the agreed total.

The Korean five-stone game. Toss one stone up and snatch stones from the ground before catching it, level by level; then flip all five onto the back of your hand and catch them. Stones caught are points.

Setup 1. Sit on the floor. Decide the order of play by jan-ken or another game. 2. Agree the winning score, for example 20 points.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 218 · large print p. 415

Hopscotch

English · England; this bed from Crockham Hill, Kent

Players 1 or more · **Time** 10–30 minutes · **Age** 4 and up

Difficulty Very easy (1 of 5)

You need chalk and a flat stone

Goal Be the first to take your stone through every division of the bed, going up and coming back.

The chalked hopping game. Throw a flat stone into each numbered division in turn and hop the bed without touching a line; then carry the stone back balanced on your thumb, eye, palm, head and back.

Setup 1. Draw the bed: 5 divisions in a line, numbered 1 to 5, with No. 1 nearest you. 2. Each player takes a stone. Agree the order of play †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 220 · large print p. 420

Jan-ken

Japanese · Japan

Players 2 or more · **Time** 1–5 minutes · **Age** 4 and up

Difficulty Very easy (1 of 5)

You need hands only

Goal Show a hand shape that beats your opponent's. Japan's three-way hand game. On the call, both players show stone, paper or scissors: stone breaks scissors, scissors cut paper, paper wraps stone. It settles who goes first, or is played as a game of its own.

Setup 1. Face each other, each holding up one fist. 2. Agree whether one throw decides, or three throws in a row, called san-jan.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 222 · large print p. 425

Jianzi

Chinese · China; also played in Korea

Players 1 or more · **Time** 5–20 minutes · **Age** 6 and up

Difficulty Easy (2 of 5)

You need a feathered shuttlecock

Goal Keep the shuttlecock in the air with your feet for as many kicks as you can.

The Chinese kicking game with a feathered shuttlecock. Kick it up with the inside of your foot, again and again, without letting it touch the ground, or pass it round a circle of players. Once it is in play, hands are not used.

Setup 1. Decide whether to play the counting game, taking turns, or the circle game together. 2. For the counting game, agree the order of turns and how many turns each †.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 224 · large print p. 430

Mbube Mbube

Zulu · South Africa

Players 12 or more · **Time** 10–20 minutes · **Age** 6 and up

Difficulty Very easy (1 of 5)

You need 2 blindfolds

Goal As the lion, catch the impala while blindfolded; as the impala, stay free.

A South African circle game. A blindfolded lion hunts a blindfolded impala inside a ring of players, who chant ‘mbube, mbube’: slowly while the lion is far away, faster and faster as it closes in.

Setup 1. Everyone except two players stands in a wide circle. 2. Choose one player to be the lion, mbube, and one to be the impala. 3. Blindfold both and stand them inside the circle, on opposite sides. 4. Agree a time limit, for example two minutes.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 226 · large print p. 435

Morra

Italian · Italy; played in ancient Rome as micatio

Players 2 · **Time** 5–10 minutes · **Age** 7 and up

Difficulty Very easy (1 of 5)

You need hands only

Goal Be the first to guess the total number of fingers an agreed number of times.

An Italian guessing game for two, played with one hand each. Both players throw out a hand at the same moment and call a number; whoever calls the total of all the fingers shown scores a point.

Setup 1. Two players face each other, each with the right fist raised. 2. Agree how many points win the game, for example 5.

Full rules, worked turn and sources: paperback and hardcover p. 228 · large print p. 440